✦ STEP 5 · NEGATIVE

The case against recognition

Two strong contentions that are hard to attack, plus backup reasons. Each one has the attack to expect and an answer ready.

💡 **FORMAT FOR EVERY ARGUMENT**

Claim (what you're saying) → **Proof** (a fact or evidence) → **So what** (why the U.S. should care).

✧ Contention 1: We already get the benefits STRONGEST

Claim: The U.S. can work with Somaliland **without** officially recognizing it.

Proof: U.S. officials have visited Somaliland and discussed more engagement, but the State Department told Congress in 2026 that the U.S. still recognizes Somalia's borders, **including Somaliland**. The U.S. treats **Taiwan** the same way: strong unofficial support, no official recognition.

So what: Why take all the risks (losing Somalia's help against al-Shabaab, angering allies, encouraging breakaways) when we already get most of the benefits?

💡 **WHY IT'S SO STRONG**

It doesn't fight the Aff's facts. It **agrees** Somaliland is a great partner and says "so what, we already work with them." That turns the Aff's democracy, location and Taiwan points into reasons the current setup works.

Attack to expect

AFF "Without recognition, Somaliland can't get World Bank loans, sign official treaties or have real embassies."

YOU "Those things help **Somaliland**, but the question is what's good for the **U.S.** The U.S. gets security cooperation either way, without the risks."

✧ Contention 2: Recognition risks the fight against al-Shabaab

STRONG

Claim: The U.S. and Somalia fight al-Shabaab together, so recognizing Somaliland risks that partnership.

Proof: U.S. airstrikes in Somalia have increased sharply: **over 130 in 2025** and **nearly 70 in the first half of 2026**, done in coordination with Somalia's government. **Hundreds of U.S. troops** are in Somalia helping Somali and African Union forces. Al-Shabaab is linked to al-Qaeda. (Your Neg evidence card.) Back in 2024, the White House warned that Ethiopia's possible recognition of Somaliland "threatens to disrupt the fight" against al-Shabaab.

So what: If Somalia stops working with the U.S., al-Shabaab could grow stronger in East Africa and put **Americans in the region** at risk.

⚠ DON'T OVERCLAIM

- Don't say "terrorism in the U.S." Al-Shabaab mostly attacks in Somalia and nearby countries like Kenya. Say "Americans in East Africa." (In 2020, al-Shabaab attacked a base in Kenya and killed three Americans. VERIFY)
- Don't say Somalia would stop fighting al-Shabaab. It's fighting for its own survival. Say it could stop **working with the U.S.**

Attack to expect

AFF "Somalia needs the U.S. more than the U.S. needs Somalia. They'd never actually cut ties."

YOU "Somalia doesn't have to fully cut ties to hurt us. It could limit where U.S. forces operate, or turn to other partners like Turkey, Egypt or China. Why take the chance when the current partnership works?"

AFF "The U.S. already cut most aid to Somalia and banned Somali nationals. The relationship is already weak."

YOU "Military cooperation is still strong. Over 130 strikes in coordination with Somalia's government in 2025 shows that."

✧ Backup reasons

Good, but easier to attack. Use them as extra support or in cross-ex.

🧩 Other regions will want to break away

In 1964, African countries agreed to **keep the old colonial borders** to avoid endless wars. Groups like the **English-speaking regions of Cameroon** and **Tigray in Ethiopia** have tried to break away. Recognizing Somaliland could encourage them, which could lead to **instability and more fighting**.

Weak spot: the Aff has the AU 2005 mission, Eritrea and South Sudan. Comeback: "Other groups won't care about the details. They'll just see that breaking away **worked**."

🗺️ Somaliland's own borders are disputed

In 2023, fighting broke out around **Las Anod**, and the people there formed their own government that joined **Somalia** instead. Somaliland doesn't even control all the land it claims, so **which borders would the U.S. be recognizing?** This hits the Aff's "same 1960 borders" argument directly.

Weak spot: the Aff will answer with Kashmir. **Word choice:** don't say Somaliland "doesn't know its borders." Say it "doesn't control all the land it claims."

🤝 Allies would be angry

When Israel recognized Somaliland in December 2025, the African Union, the EU, Egypt, Saudi Arabia and China all condemned it, and **no other country followed**. The U.S. needs these partners for trade, security and UN votes.

Weak spot: the Aff will bring up Kosovo (recognized by the U.S. in 2008 despite Serbia and Russia).

📜 It joined willingly

Somaliland **chose** to join Somalia in 1960. You can't just leave a country because you're unhappy with how it turned out. If any region can leave after a bad government, lots of regions could leave.

✧ Answers to the Aff's best arguments

Aff says	You answer
"It meets the Montevideo test; it's already a country."	"Then nothing changes if we don't recognize it. It keeps running itself, and we keep working with it. Recognition only adds risk." Also: "It doesn't control all its territory, as Las Anod shows."
"Its case is unique; no domino effect."	"Other groups won't read an AU report from 2005. They'll see that breaking away worked. And the AU itself now calls recognition a 'dangerous precedent.'"
"It's a democracy; reward it."	"We can reward it with trade, aid and visits without breaking up a partner country."
"We need Berbera to balance China in Djibouti."	"Somaliland has already offered access. We don't need recognition to use a port, and the 2026 State Department report already points to Berbera for engagement."
"Your evidence is old" or "biased."	"The facts haven't changed, and several other sources report the same thing."